future, it is easy to imagine how ‘his heart was greatly delighted’,[57] and relieved, when, sometime after that complaint about Akbar’s indiscipline, Humayun received another, altogether different kind of report about his son. Akbar had gone to hunt at the foot of a range of snow-capped mountains outside Kabul. His idea was to have his dogs catch deer, to which effect he commanded one group of men to chase deer down the mountain slopes, and another to release the dogs at their approach. The latter lot of men grew peckish as they waited; when the deer came hurtling down, they were eating. The dogs were not released.

The men, writes Abul Fazl, had misunderstood the prince’s ‘tender years and boyish appearance’. His wrath they would appreciate all too clearly. The men were put in collars and chains, like the dogs they had failed to let loose, and ‘led round the camp’. When Humayun heard the news, he understood his son was learning – if not his alphabet, then how to rule.

The lessons were not all easy. An ability to command would attract followers, naturally; and it was equally, perhaps instinctively, clear to Akbar, who had grown up in plain sight of the fleeting loyalties of his father’s and uncle’s chiefs, that he must be wary of their flattery. Perhaps instinctive suspicion falls to the lot of those born to rule. There is even a theory that both Akbar’s name and birth date were changed during the festival of his circumcision, ‘to protect him against the perils of malignant sorcery’.[58] Thus, anticipating betrayal since infancy, Akbar would get angry if a courtier spoke too eagerly of the glorious future that awaited the prince when he became king. What kind of well-wisher encouraged a prince to covet his father’s realm? ‘They [were] imagining evil for me in thinking of the decease of His Majesty [Humayun],’ Akbar would say of the wagging of their tongues; they were ‘gathering my temporal good from my spiritual ill’.[59]

At nine, Akbar wasn’t just learning how to master animals and men, he was also acquiring a bleaker talent: to appraise the people around him and gauge their ambitions, to measure the worth of his own life in their eyes.

At ten, he would learn the most chilling lesson of his young life.

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For a year and more, Kamran had sought shelter and allies amongst the